Cross that had been taken from Jerusalem during the conquest.

The city duly surrendered. But on either Saladin's side or Richard's (depending on whose chronicles you read), the deal broke down. On August 20, Richard marched out nearly three thousand prisoners and slaughtered them within sight of Saladin's headquarters.*

This ended the possibility of any more negotiations, and Saladin prepared his army for an all-out war. Richard took command of the Crusader army; Philip had decided to go home.

Roger of Hoveden, who traveled back with the French king (and recorded his every move in excruciating geographical detail), writes that Philip stopped in Rome, on the way, and "said many evil things of the king of England" to Pope Celestine III. He wanted the pope to release him from his treaty of friendship with Richard, so that he could attack Richard's lands in the English king's absence. Celestine refused. Still bound by the oath, Philip made a deal with the Holy Roman Emperor Henry VI instead: "to lay hands upon the king of England, in case he should pass through his territory."[14]

Unaware of the Christian hostiles arraying against him, Richard was marching south towards the port city of Jaffa, which he hoped to capture in order to assure a steady stream of supplies for his army. Saladin attempted to block him, and the two generals met north of Arsuf, on September 7, 1191.

Possibly Saladin had underestimated his enemy; Richard planned the battle carefully, breaking the opposing line in three places with his cavalry so that his foot soldiers could rush through into the body of the Muslim army. Ibn Shaddad, who himself fought in the battle, says that the Muslim front was "broken utterly . . . the Muslims were, in fact, in a complete rout." It was a devastating defeat for Saladin, and a turning point in the war; Saladin would never face Richard in pitched battle again.[15]

Over the next year, the two men sparred, raided, and negotiated, always through intermediaries; when Richard suggested a face-to-face meeting, Saladin refused, explaining that kings could not fight properly against each other once they had met. It was becoming clear to both that victory would go to neither. Richard was too strong to be driven away; Saladin was too powerful to relinquish Jerusalem. Meanwhile, Richard was hearing alarming reports from home: Philip II was trying to persuade Richard's younger brother John to seize Richard's English territories and was planning on taking the lands in Western Francia for himself.[16]

After lengthy negotiations, representatives from both sides agreed to a treaty at the city of Ramla. The terms, finalized and sworn to on September 3, 1192, imposed a three-year peace. Richard would hand over captured territories to Saladin; Christian-held land on the coast would be left alone;